

10 YARDS AT A TIME

Territory and possession of the ball are the keys to success in American football. The team in possession of the ball is called the offence. It has four chances, called "downs", to advance the ball 10 yd (9 m) towards the opponent's end zone, either by running with the ball or by throwing it. If successful, the offensive team is awarded another four downs. If it fails to advance 10 yd (9 m), or if it loses possession of the ball during a play, possession of the ball passes to the defensive team.

BASIC DEFENCE

The aim of the defence is to stop the offence from gaining the 10 yd (9 m) they require to gain four new downs. Many teams use a formation called the 4-3 defence, in which four defensive linemen line up in front of the three linebackers. Two safeties play behind to stop longer passes and runs, while two cornerbacks are positioned to cover any passes made to the wide receivers.

There are five positions in defence:

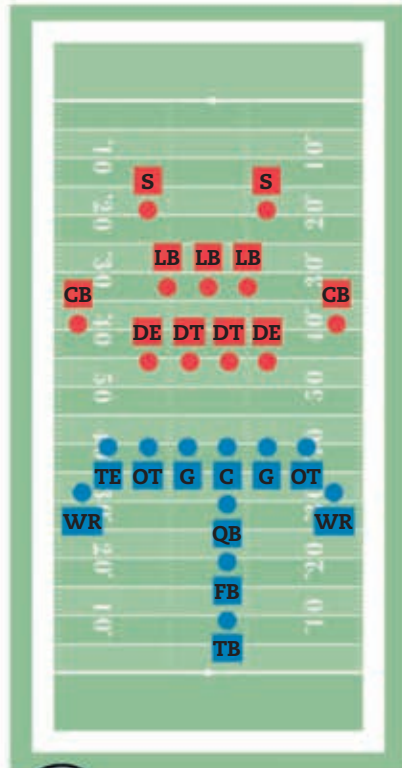
DE	Defensive end
DT	Defensive tackle
LB	Linebacker
CB	Cornerback
S	Safety

BASIC OFFENCE

The "Standard I Formation" is a common attacking play using five offensive linemen. The "I" refers to the line formed by the quarterback, fullback, and tailback, or running back. A tight end lines up on one side, with a wide receiver at each end.

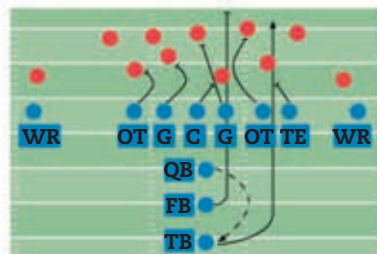
There are eight positions in offence:

WR	Wide receiver
TE	Tight end
OT	Offensive tackle
G	Guard
C	Centre
QB	Quarterback
FB	Fullback
TB	Tailback, or running back



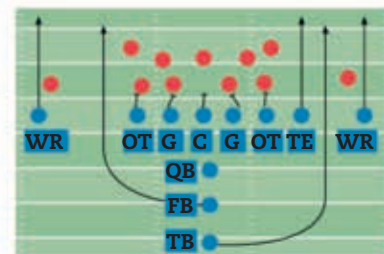
PLAYS

American football is punctuated by a series of plays, or downs. Offensive plays aim to advance the ball towards the opponents' end zone. Defensive plays aim to stop the offence moving forwards. Some of the most well-known plays are described below.



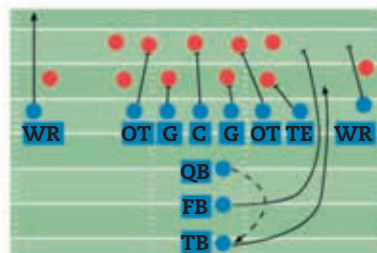
TAILBACK OFF-TACKLE

The tailback off-tackle is the most common running play in offence. The quarterback hands the ball to the tailback, who runs through a hole created by the offensive tackle and the tight end.



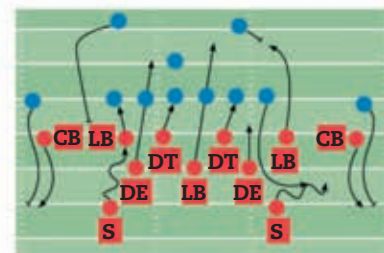
HAIL MARY

The Hail Mary is a passing play in which the quarterback throws a long ball towards one of a number of receivers. The play is often used as a last resort by a trailing team towards the end of the game.



SWEEP

The sweep is an organized offensive running play in which a tailback receives the ball from the quarterback and then runs parallel to the line of scrimmage. This gives the fullback and offensive linemen time to create a gap for the tailback.



THE BLITZ

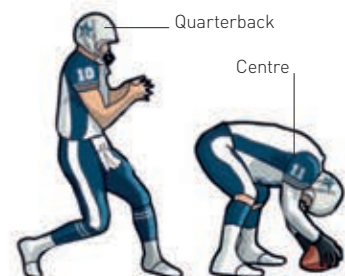
The blitz is a defensive tactic used to combat passing plays. The aim is to put the opposition quarterback under pressure by swamping the offence with defenders.

KEY SKILLS

Different positions require different skills. For example, quarterbacks need to be good at throwing; wide receivers must have lightning acceleration and be able to catch the ball; and defenders must be excellent tacklers and blockers.

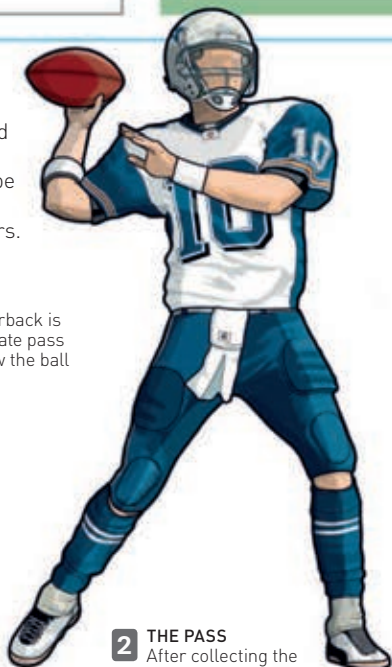
PASSING THE BALL

One of the most important duties of a quarterback is to pass the ball to a receiver. A strong, accurate pass is vital, as the quarterback may have to throw the ball over a long distance.



1 THE SNAP

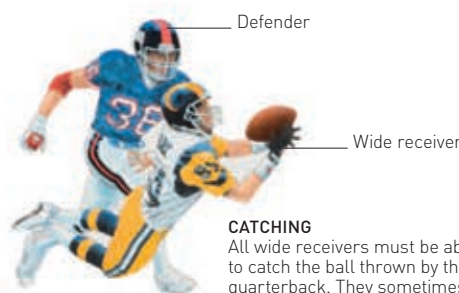
The centre snaps the ball through his legs to the quarterback.



2 THE PASS

After collecting the ball, the quarterback grips the ball by the laces and passes it point first. The ball is spun as it is thrown, making it fly straight.

ON AVERAGE, THE NFL HAS MORE SPECTATORS PER GAME THAN ANY OTHER SPORTING LEAGUE IN THE WORLD - 68,331 IN 2014

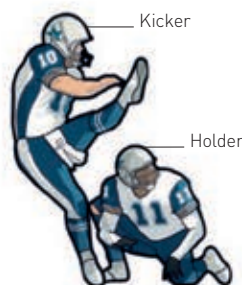


CATCHING

All wide receivers must be able to catch the ball thrown by the quarterback. They sometimes do this running at full speed, and often while having to fight off a defender.

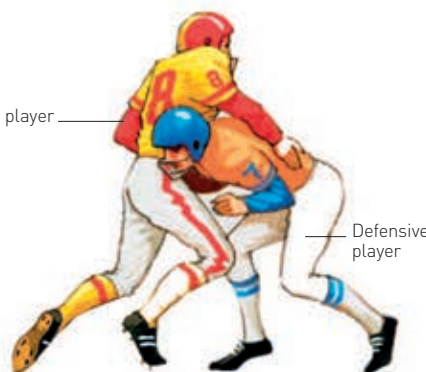
KICKING

All American football teams have a specialist kicker. His or her role is to kick for field goals or for the extra point following a touchdown. For a field goal attempt, the holder stands 7 yd (6 m) behind the centre, who snaps the ball to him. The holder catches the ball and sets it up for the kicker. The kicker steps forwards and swings his foot through the ball, aiming to send it between the goal posts.



DEFENCE

The main task of a defender is to prevent the offensive side from advancing with the ball. He or she can do this by tackling the offensive player who is carrying the ball.



REFEREE'S SIGNALS

If a rule is broken during the course of a game, an official will bring play to a halt by waving a yellow flag. The referee then conveys the decision by using a hand signal and making an announcement.



INTERFERENCE

A penalty in which a player has interfered with another player during a play.



FIRST DOWN

The offence advances 10 yd (9 m) within four downs, so a new series of downs is called.



FALSE START

This is called when a member of the offence moves illegally before the ball is snapped.



OFFSIDE

A defensive player is on the wrong side of the line of scrimmage at the start of play.



HOLDING

A penalty in which a player of either side has illegally held an opponent.



ILLEGAL BALL TOUCH

A penalty in which the ball is illegally touched, kicked, or batted.